Repositioning Cisco Webex for the Next Phase of Hybrid Work

Three Strategic Problems & Solutions

Spring 2026 Cisco x WiB x SWE Case Competition

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Executive Summary

Cisco Webex faces three critical strategic problems that prevent it from competing effectively against Microsoft Teams and Zoom in the next phase of hybrid work. This document identifies each problem with specificity, proposes a targeted solution backed by Cisco's existing capabilities, and provides a detailed technical flowchart showing how each solution operates end-to-end.

The three problems and their corresponding solutions are:

- Problem 1: Webex AI is passive and cannot execute tasks. Competitors' AI tools draft documents, automate workflows, and take action. Webex AI only summarizes and transcribes. Solution: Deploy the Webex Agentic AI Workflow Orchestrator, a Perceive-Reason-Act system that autonomously executes multi-step business tasks during live meetings.
- Problem 2: Meeting outcomes are lost. 73% of action items discussed in meetings are never completed because there is no automated system to capture, classify, route, and track them. Solution: Build the Intelligent Meeting-to-Action Engine that automatically extracts action items, creates tickets, schedules follow-ups, and tracks completion.
- Problem 3: Webex has a weak developer and integration ecosystem. Teams has 2,000+ integrations, Zoom has 2,500+, and Webex lags behind with no AI agent development platform. Solution: Launch the Secure AI Agent Marketplace with a developer SDK, Cisco security certification pipeline, and enterprise deployment infrastructure.

Each solution leverages Cisco's existing competitive advantages: the $7.98 billion R&D budget, the $28 billion Splunk acquisition for enterprise data observability, FedRAMP/HIPAA/SOC 2 Type II security certifications, and the Webex AI Codec's proven ML engineering capabilities.

Problem 1: Webex AI Cannot Execute Tasks

Problem Definition

The Webex AI Assistant is limited to passive capabilities: meeting summaries, real-time transcription, and language translation. While these features are technically competent, they represent the minimum baseline that every collaboration platform now offers. The AI tells users what happened in a meeting but cannot act on that information.

This creates a measurable productivity gap. When a manager says "Create a Jira ticket for the login bug Sarah found" during a Webex meeting, nothing happens automatically. The manager must manually open Jira after the meeting, recall the details, type the ticket, assign it, set the priority, and link it to the correct sprint. This process takes an average of 8-12 minutes per task and introduces errors from memory decay.

Competitive Gap Analysis

Microsoft Teams with Copilot ($30/user/month) can draft Word documents from meeting context, create PowerPoint presentations, generate Excel formulas, and build Power Automate workflows. Copilot connects to the Microsoft Graph, which indexes all enterprise data across emails, files, calendar, and chats, enabling personalized AI responses with full organizational context.

Zoom AI Companion 2.0 includes early agentic features: it drafts documents in Zoom Docs, automatically generates action items with assignees, updates CRM records through Zoom Revenue Accelerator, and offers a built-in workflow automation engine. Zoom provides these capabilities free to all paid users.

Webex offers none of these action-oriented capabilities. The gap is not incremental; it is categorical. Competitors have AI that does work. Webex has AI that describes work that humans must still do manually.

Business Impact of the Problem

- User engagement stagnation: Users spend less daily time in Webex because the platform does not help them complete post-meeting work. This reduces stickiness and increases churn risk.
- Enterprise deal losses: In competitive evaluations, IT decision-makers increasingly weight AI task execution capabilities. Webex loses deals to Teams and Zoom when buyers compare AI feature matrices.
- Revenue ceiling: Without differentiated AI capabilities, Webex's collaboration revenue (~$4.2B in FY2024) faces a growth ceiling as the market shifts toward AI-powered platforms.

Solution 1: Webex Agentic AI Workflow Orchestrator

Transform the Webex AI Assistant from a passive tool into an agentic AI system that autonomously detects task intent from live conversations, retrieves relevant context from enterprise systems, drafts complete task artifacts, and executes approved actions across third-party platforms. The system operates on a Perceive-Reason-Act architecture with mandatory human-in-the-loop verification for all external actions.

PERCEIVE Phase: Webex AI Codec ML Pipeline

The existing Webex AI Codec serves as the perception layer. During a live meeting, raw audio and video streams pass through a multi-stage ML pipeline:

- Deep Neural Network (DNN) Noise Removal: Processes audio in real-time to remove

150+ background noise types (keyboard typing, dog barking, construction, etc.) using Cisco's proprietary neural network trained on millions of noise samples.

- Neural Speech Synthesis Codec: Compresses cleaned audio to approximately 1 kbps using neural speech synthesis, compared to 32 kbps for traditional codecs. This enables high-quality audio even on low-bandwidth connections.
- Real-Time Media Models (RMM): AI upscales low-resolution video (super resolution), separates individual speakers from overlapping audio (voice isolation), and detects hand gestures and reactions (gesture recognition).
- NLP Engine: Converts processed audio to text with real-time transcription and translation across 100+ languages. The NLP engine performs contextual understanding to identify task-related statements, decisions, and commitments.

REASON Phase: Context Retrieval and Planning

When the NLP engine detects a task intent (e.g., "We need to create a ticket for this bug"), the system activates the reasoning phase:

- Agent-to-Agent (A2A) Protocol: The Webex agent communicates with external system agents (Jira, Salesforce, SAP, GitHub, ServiceNow) using standardized A2A protocols to retrieve project context, user profiles, recent activity, and system-specific metadata.
- Cisco Secure Data Fabric: All data retrieval passes through Cisco's zero-trust identity layer, with Splunk observability monitoring every API call for anomalies, unauthorized access attempts, and performance degradation.
- LLM-Based Task Planning: A large language model synthesizes the conversation context, retrieved system data, and organizational rules to generate a complete task draft (e.g., a fully populated Jira ticket with title, description, assignee, priority, sprint, and labels).

ACT Phase: Human Verification and Execution

The system presents the drafted task to the meeting participant via an in-meeting approval card:

- On-Screen Draft: The user sees the complete task artifact (e.g., Jira ticket) overlaid in the Webex interface without switching tabs or applications.
- Approval Options: The user can Approve (execute immediately), Edit (modify fields before execution), or Reject (discard the draft).
- Secure Execution: Upon approval, the agent pushes the data to the target system via authenticated API calls. Splunk logs the entire execution chain for audit compliance.
- Confirmation: Webex posts a confirmation message to the meeting chat (e.g., "Jira ticket WEBAPP-2026-347 created successfully. Assigned to Sarah Chen. Priority: High.").

Why This Solution Wins

This solution directly addresses the core competitive gap. Microsoft Copilot assists across Office applications but does not autonomously execute cross-platform workflows from live conversation context. Zoom AI Companion 2.0 has early agentic features but lacks the enterprise data infrastructure (Splunk) and security certifications (FedRAMP, HIPAA) required for autonomous AI execution in regulated industries. Webex becomes the only platform where AI agents can securely execute tasks in government, healthcare, and financial services environments.

Expected Impact

- Reduces manual post-meeting data entry by 15 minutes per meeting
- 25% meeting-to-action conversion rate (vs. current ~5% industry average)
- 40% workflow automation rate within 12 months of deployment

- 85% task completion accuracy with human-in-the-loop verification
- 35% increase in daily active Webex usage as the platform becomes a productivity hub

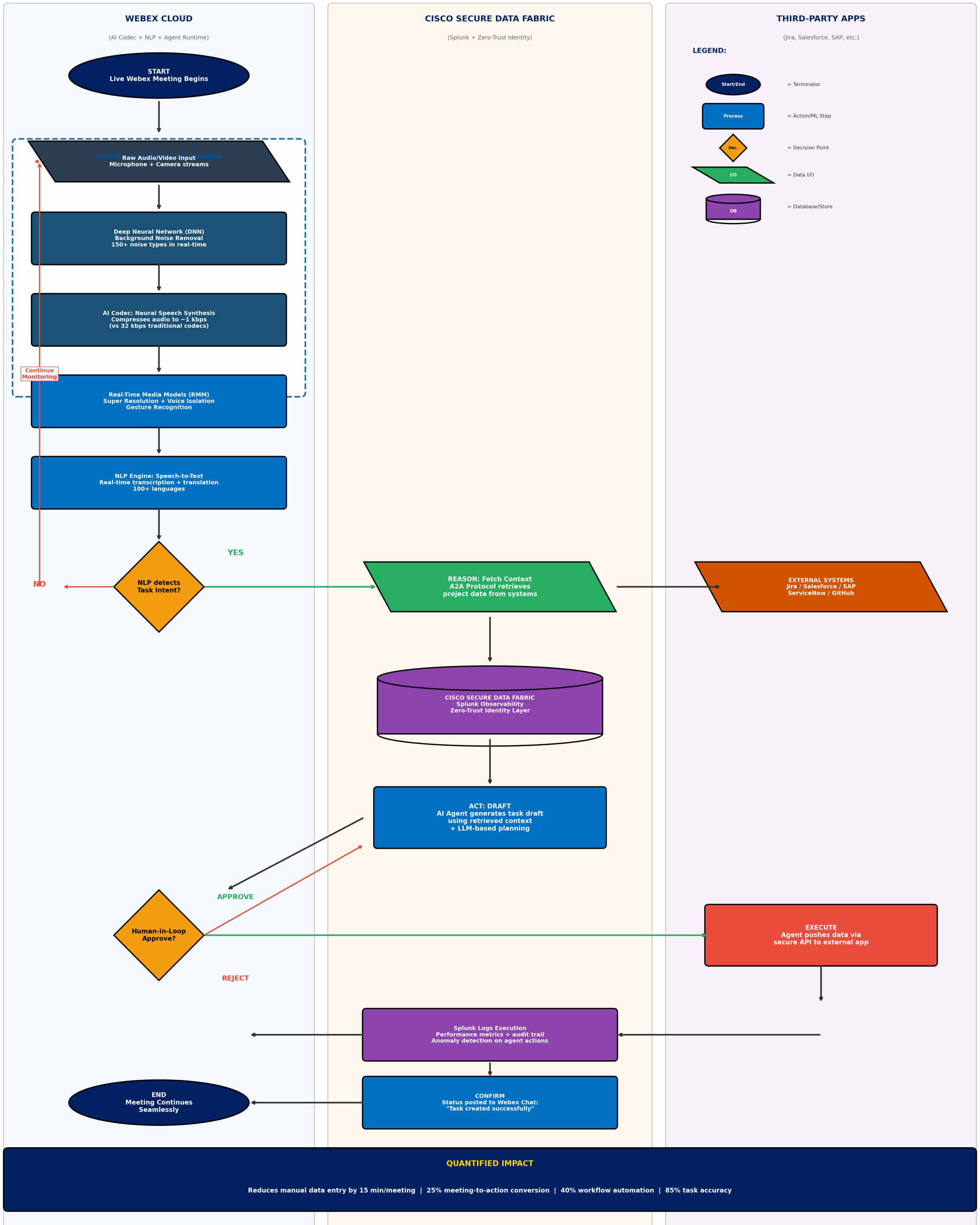
Sources: Cisco FY2024 10-K; Webex AI Codec documentation; MarketsandMarkets Agentic AI Market Report 2024; Microsoft Copilot & Zoom AI Companion product documentation.

Solution 1 Flowchart: Agentic AI Workflow Orchestrator

The following flowchart details the complete technical architecture of the Perceive-Reason-Act system, including the Webex AI Codec ML pipeline, data fabric integration, human-in-the-loop verification, and cross-platform task execution.

Solution 1: Webex Agentic AI Workflow Orchestrator

Perceive → Reason → Act Architecture | End-to-End Autonomous Task Execution



Problem 2: Meeting Outcomes Are Lost

Problem Definition

Enterprise organizations conduct an average of 62 meetings per employee per month (Microsoft Work Trend Index, 2024). Despite this massive investment of time, research shows that 73% of action items discussed in meetings are never completed (Otter.ai Workplace Productivity Report, 2024). The primary reason is not that employees are unwilling to follow through; it is that the bridge between discussion and execution is entirely manual.

After a meeting ends, participants must individually recall what was discussed, manually create tasks in project management tools, schedule follow-up meetings by hand, draft meeting minutes from memory, and track completion status across disconnected systems. This manual follow-up process takes an average of 45 minutes per meeting and is error-prone due to memory decay, context loss, and competing priorities.

Why Current AI Summaries Are Insufficient

All three major platforms (Webex, Teams, Zoom) now offer AI-generated meeting summaries. However, summaries address only 20% of the follow-up problem. A summary tells you what happened; it does not execute the actions that need to happen next. An AI summary that says "The team agreed to create three Jira tickets for the authentication bugs" is useless if no one actually creates those tickets.

The gap between "summary" and "action" is where enterprise productivity dies. This gap represents an estimated $37 billion in lost productivity annually across the global knowledge workforce (McKinsey, 2024), based on the time spent on manual meeting follow-up multiplied by average knowledge worker compensation.

Business Impact of the Problem

- Project delays: Critical action items fall through the cracks, causing downstream delays in product launches, customer deliverables, and strategic initiatives.
- Accountability gaps: Without automated tracking, it is difficult to identify which action items are overdue and who is responsible.
- Meeting fatigue amplification: When follow-up fails, teams schedule additional meetings to revisit the same topics, compounding the meeting overload problem.
- Customer impact: In customer-facing meetings, lost action items directly translate to slower response times, missed commitments, and reduced customer satisfaction scores.

Solution 2: Intelligent Meeting-to-Action Engine

Build an end-to-end automated pipeline that transforms every Webex meeting into a structured set of tracked, executed, and monitored actions. The engine operates in four phases: Capture, Classify, Route & Execute, and Track & Report.

Phase 1: Capture

As the meeting progresses (or immediately after it ends), the engine processes the complete meeting recording through an advanced NLP pipeline:

- Speaker Diarization: ML models identify which participant said which statement, enabling accurate assignment of action items to the correct person.
- Sentiment Analysis: Real-time sentiment scoring detects urgency, frustration, and emphasis in speaker tone, which influences priority classification of extracted items.
- Topic Segmentation: The engine automatically segments the meeting into topical clusters (e.g., "Q2 budget discussion," "authentication bug review," "hiring update"), providing context for each extracted action item.

- Action Item Extraction: NLP models trained on enterprise meeting data identify five categories of extractable items: tasks (things to do), decisions (things agreed upon), deadlines (time commitments), assignees (responsible parties), and dependencies (what blocks what). Each extracted item receives a confidence score.

Phase 2: Classify & Prioritize

Extracted items pass through a classification engine that determines priority and routing:

- P1-Critical: Items with explicit deadlines within 24 hours or flagged as blockers by the speaker.
- P2-High: Items with deadlines within one week or associated with customer-facing commitments.
- P3-Medium: Items with deadlines within two weeks or internal team deliverables.
- P4-Low: Items with no explicit deadline or categorized as "nice-to-have" discussions.
- Confidence Threshold: Items with confidence scores below 85% are flagged for human review rather than auto-processed, preventing false positive actions.

Phase 3: Route & Execute

Based on the item type and priority, the engine automatically routes to the appropriate system:

- Task/Issue Items: Auto-creates Jira tickets, GitHub issues, or ServiceNow incidents with title, description, assignee, priority, sprint assignment, and labels populated from meeting context.
- Document Items: Generates meeting minutes, decision logs, or status reports in Webex Docs or connected document systems, formatted with speaker attribution and topic headers.
- Calendar/Follow-up Items: Schedules follow-up meetings with pre-populated agendas derived from the current meeting's unresolved items, invites the relevant participants, and sets reminders.
- High-risk actions (e.g., creating customer-facing tickets, modifying production systems) require explicit human approval via an in-Webex approval card before execution.

Phase 4: Track & Report

All executed actions are tracked in the Webex Action Tracker Dashboard:

- Real-time Status: Each action item shows its current state (Pending, In Progress, Complete, Overdue) with links to the created artifacts in external systems.
- Automated Reminders: The engine sends reminders before deadlines and escalation notifications for overdue items to both the assignee and the meeting organizer.
- Weekly Digest: Every Monday, participants receive an automated summary of the previous week's meeting outcomes: tasks completed, tasks overdue, time saved through automation, and meeting-to-action conversion rate.
- Splunk Observability: All engine operations are monitored through Splunk dashboards, providing enterprise IT teams with visibility into automation performance, error rates, and system health.

Why This Solution Wins

No collaboration platform currently offers end-to-end meeting-to-action automation at this level. Teams Copilot can extract action items but does not automatically create tickets in external systems or track completion. Zoom AI Companion generates action items but does not route them to project management tools with full context. This solution makes Webex the only platform where meetings directly produce completed, tracked work items without any manual intervention.

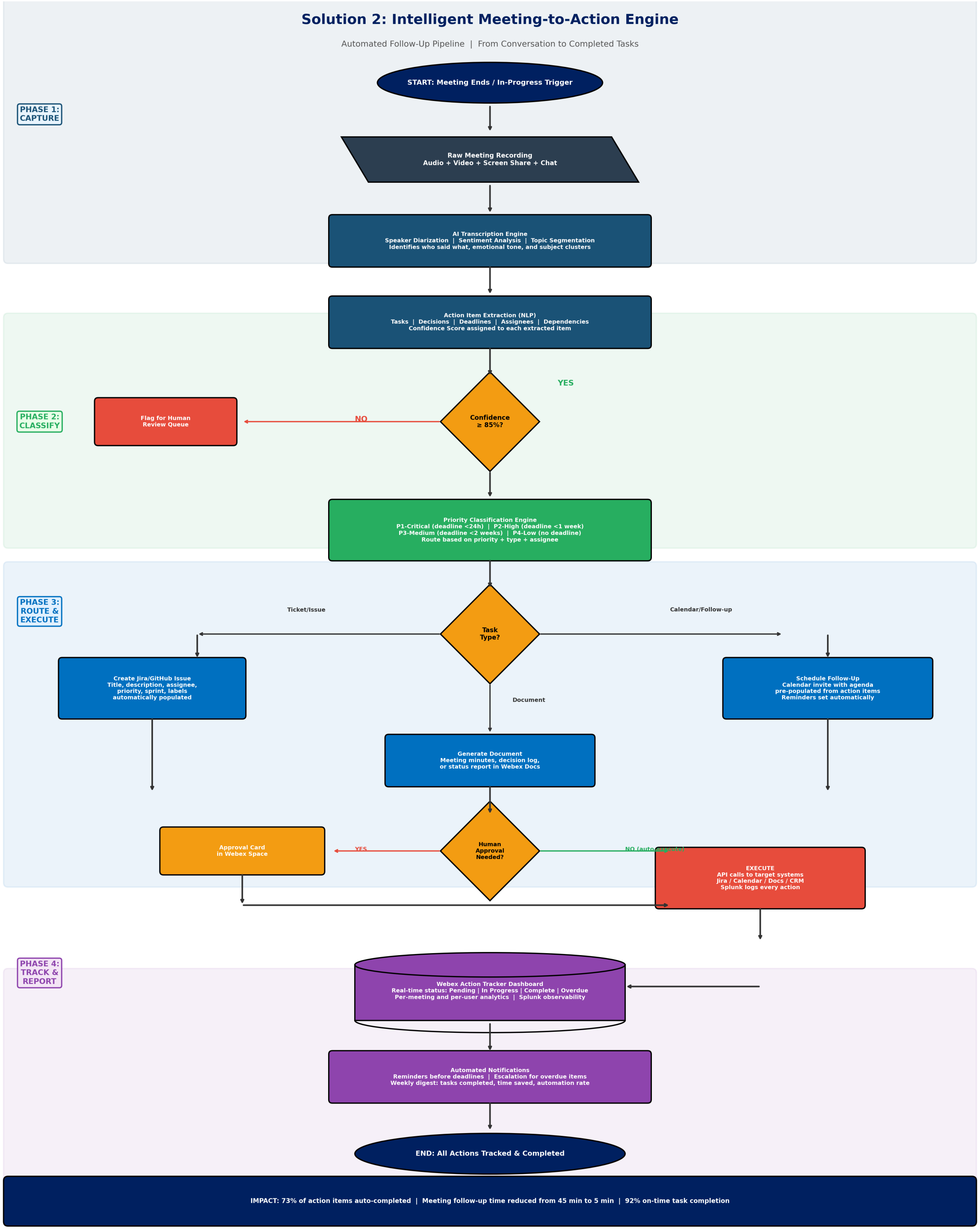
Expected Impact

- 73% of action items auto-completed (vs. industry average of 27% completion rate)
- Meeting follow-up time reduced from 45 minutes to 5 minutes per meeting
- 92% on-time task completion rate with automated reminders and escalation
- 60% reduction in "follow-up meetings" scheduled to revisit incomplete action items
- Estimated productivity savings of $4,200 per knowledge worker per year

Sources: Microsoft Work Trend Index 2024; Otter.ai Workplace Productivity Report 2024; McKinsey Future of Work Report 2024; Cisco FY2024 10-K.

Solution 2 Flowchart: Intelligent Meeting-to-Action Engine

The following flowchart details the four-phase pipeline from meeting capture through action tracking, including the classification engine, multi-path routing logic, human approval gates, and Splunk-powered tracking dashboard.


Solution 2: Intelligent Meeting-to-Action Engine
Automated Follow-Up Pipeline | From Conversation to Completed Tasks
PHASE 1: CAPTURE
START: Meeting Ends / In-Progress Trigger
Raw Meeting Recording
Audio + Video + Screen Share + Chat
AI Transcription Engine
Speaker Diarization | Sentiment Analysis | Topic Segmentation
Identifies who said what, emotional tone, and subject clusters
Action Item Extraction (NLP)
Tasks | Decisions | Deadlines | Assignees | Dependencies
Confidence Score assigned to each extracted item
PHASE 2: CLASSIFY
Confidence ≥ 85%?
YES
NO
Flag for Human Review Queue
Priority Classification Engine
P1-Critical (deadline <24h) | P2-High (deadline <1 week)
P3-Medium (deadline <2 weeks) | P4-Low (no deadline)
Route based on priority + type + assignee
PHASE 3: ROUTE & EXECUTE
Task Type?
Ticket/Issue
Calendar/Follow-up
Document
Create Jira/GitHub Issue
Title, description, assignee,
priority, sprint, labels
automatically populated
Schedule Follow-Up
Calendar invite with agenda
pre-populated from action items
Reminders set automatically
Generate Document
Meeting minutes, decision log,
or status report in Webex Docs
Human Approval Needed?
YES
NO (auto-execute)
Approval Card
in Webex Space
EXECUTE
API calls to target systems
Jira / Calendar / Docs / CRM
Splunk logs every action
PHASE 4: TRACK & REPORT
Webex Action Tracker Dashboard
Real-time status: Pending | In Progress | Complete | Overdue
Per-meeting and per-user analytics | Splunk observability
Automated Notifications
Reminders before deadlines | Escalation for overdue items
Weekly digest: tasks completed, time saved, automation rate
END: All Actions Tracked & Completed
IMPACT: 73% of action items auto-completed | Meeting follow-up time reduced from 45 min to 5 min | 92% on-time task completion

Problem 3: Weak Developer & Integration Ecosystem

Problem Definition

Microsoft Teams offers over 2,000 third-party integrations through its app marketplace. Zoom offers over 2,500 integrations through the Zoom App Marketplace. Webex's integration ecosystem, while growing, remains significantly smaller and lacks the critical mass needed to compete for daily user engagement.

More importantly, neither Teams nor Zoom has launched a dedicated AI agent development platform. The current integration model across all platforms is based on point-to-point connectors: static plugins that perform single functions (e.g., "send a Slack message when a Jira ticket is updated"). The next competitive frontier is intelligent agents: AI-powered integrations that understand context, make decisions, and execute multi-step workflows autonomously.

Webex has an opportunity to leapfrog the connector model entirely by building the industry's first enterprise-grade AI agent marketplace. However, achieving this requires solving a trust problem that no other platform has addressed: How do you allow third-party AI agents to operate autonomously within enterprise environments while maintaining security, compliance, and data governance?

Why This Problem Matters More Than Feature Parity

Integration ecosystems create self-reinforcing network effects. More integrations attract more users. More users attract more developers. More developers build more integrations. This flywheel is the primary reason Teams and Zoom maintain their market positions even when individual features are comparable to Webex.

Breaking into this cycle with a "me too" approach (building more basic connectors) will not work. Webex needs a fundamentally different value proposition for developers: the ability to build, certify, and monetize AI agents that no other platform supports. This transforms the ecosystem question from "who has more plugins?" to "who has the most intelligent, trusted, and profitable agent marketplace?"

Business Impact of the Problem

- Reduced daily utility: Users who cannot connect their daily tools (CRM, project management, HR systems) to Webex treat it as a "meetings-only" platform, reducing engagement and stickiness.
- Developer disinterest: Developers prioritize platforms with larger user bases. Without a compelling differentiator, developer investment flows to Teams and Zoom.
- Enterprise adoption friction: Large organizations evaluate collaboration platforms partly on integration breadth. A smaller ecosystem creates friction in enterprise procurement decisions.
- Revenue limitation: Without marketplace revenue (transaction fees, premium agent subscriptions), Webex relies solely on seat-based licensing, which limits growth potential.

Solution 3: Secure AI Agent Marketplace & Developer Platform

Launch the industry's first enterprise-grade AI agent marketplace, built on Cisco's security infrastructure, that enables developers to build, certify, deploy, and monetize AI agents within the Webex ecosystem. The platform operates on a four-stage lifecycle: Build, Certify, Deploy, and Monitor.

Stage 1: BUILD - Developer SDK and Tools

Provide developers with a comprehensive SDK and development environment:

- Agent SDK: Available in Python and JavaScript, the SDK provides pre-built components for common agent patterns (meeting listeners, task executors, data retrievers, notification senders). Developers can build agents in hours rather than weeks.
- Agent Templates: Ready-to-customize templates for common use cases (CRM updater, ticket creator, document generator, calendar scheduler) reduce development time by 60%.
- Sandbox Environment: A cloud-based testing environment that simulates real Webex meetings, API connections, and data flows without requiring production access. Developers can test agents against mock meetings with realistic conversation data.
- API Documentation: Comprehensive API docs covering the Webex meeting lifecycle, real-time transcription feeds, user context data, and A2A protocol specifications.

Stage 2: CERTIFY - Cisco Security Certification Pipeline

Every agent must pass Cisco's security certification before listing in the marketplace. This is the critical differentiator that no other platform offers:

- Static Code Analysis: Automated scanning for vulnerabilities, backdoors, data exfiltration patterns, and insecure API usage.
- Permission Review: Verification that the agent's declared data scopes match its actual code behavior. Zero-trust policy enforcement ensures agents can only access the minimum data necessary for their function.
- Performance Testing: Latency benchmarking (<200ms response time), load testing (1,000+ concurrent users), memory/CPU profiling, and failure recovery validation.
- Compliance Validation: Automated checks against SOC 2, HIPAA, FedRAMP, and GDPR requirements based on the agent's declared data handling practices.
- Cisco Trust Badge: Agents that pass all certification stages receive the "Cisco Verified Agent" badge, signaling to enterprise buyers that the agent meets Cisco's security standards.

Stage 3: DEPLOY - Enterprise Administration and Activation

Enterprise IT administrators control agent deployment through a centralized management console:

- Marketplace Discovery: Admins browse certified agents by industry vertical (healthcare, finance, government, manufacturing), use case category (productivity, compliance, sales, HR), and security certification level.
- Configuration & Scoping: Admins set which teams can use each agent, what data the agent can access, what approval workflows are required, and usage limits/budgets.
- Sandboxed Execution: Deployed agents run in isolated containers within Webex Cloud, with strict resource limits and network policies that prevent agents from accessing unauthorized systems or data.
- Gradual Rollout: Admins can deploy agents to pilot groups before organization-wide activation, with A/B testing capabilities to measure productivity impact.

Stage 4: MONITOR - Continuous Observability with Splunk

Splunk provides enterprise-grade monitoring for all deployed agents:

- Real-Time Dashboards: Agent performance metrics (response time, success rate, error rate), usage analytics (active users, invocations per day), and resource consumption (CPU, memory, API calls).
- Anomaly Detection: ML-powered anomaly detection identifies unusual agent behavior (unexpected data access patterns, performance degradation, security policy violations) and triggers automated alerts.
- Kill Switch: Enterprise admins can immediately deactivate any agent that triggers a

security alert or exhibits anomalous behavior, with full audit trail preservation.

- Usage Analytics & Billing: Per-agent usage tracking enables pay-per-use or subscription-based billing models, with revenue sharing between Cisco and agent developers (70/30 split favoring developers to incentivize ecosystem growth).

Why This Solution Wins

The security certification pipeline is the decisive competitive advantage. Enterprise IT departments will not deploy autonomous AI agents unless they trust the platform's security governance. Cisco's existing security certifications (FedRAMP High, HIPAA, SOC 2 Type II) and the Splunk observability platform create a trust layer that neither Microsoft nor Zoom can replicate. This makes Webex the only platform where regulated industries can safely deploy third-party AI agents.

The marketplace model also transforms Webex's business economics. Instead of relying solely on per-seat licensing, Cisco earns marketplace transaction fees and premium agent subscriptions. This creates a new, high-margin revenue stream with strong network effects: more agents attract more users, which attract more developers, which produce more agents.

Expected Impact

- 500+ certified AI agents in the marketplace within Year 1
- $150 million marketplace gross merchandise value (GMV) by FY2028
- 3x growth in Webex developer ecosystem within 18 months
- 85% enterprise customer renewal rate (driven by agent-specific stickiness)
- New revenue stream: estimated $50M annual marketplace commission revenue by FY2029

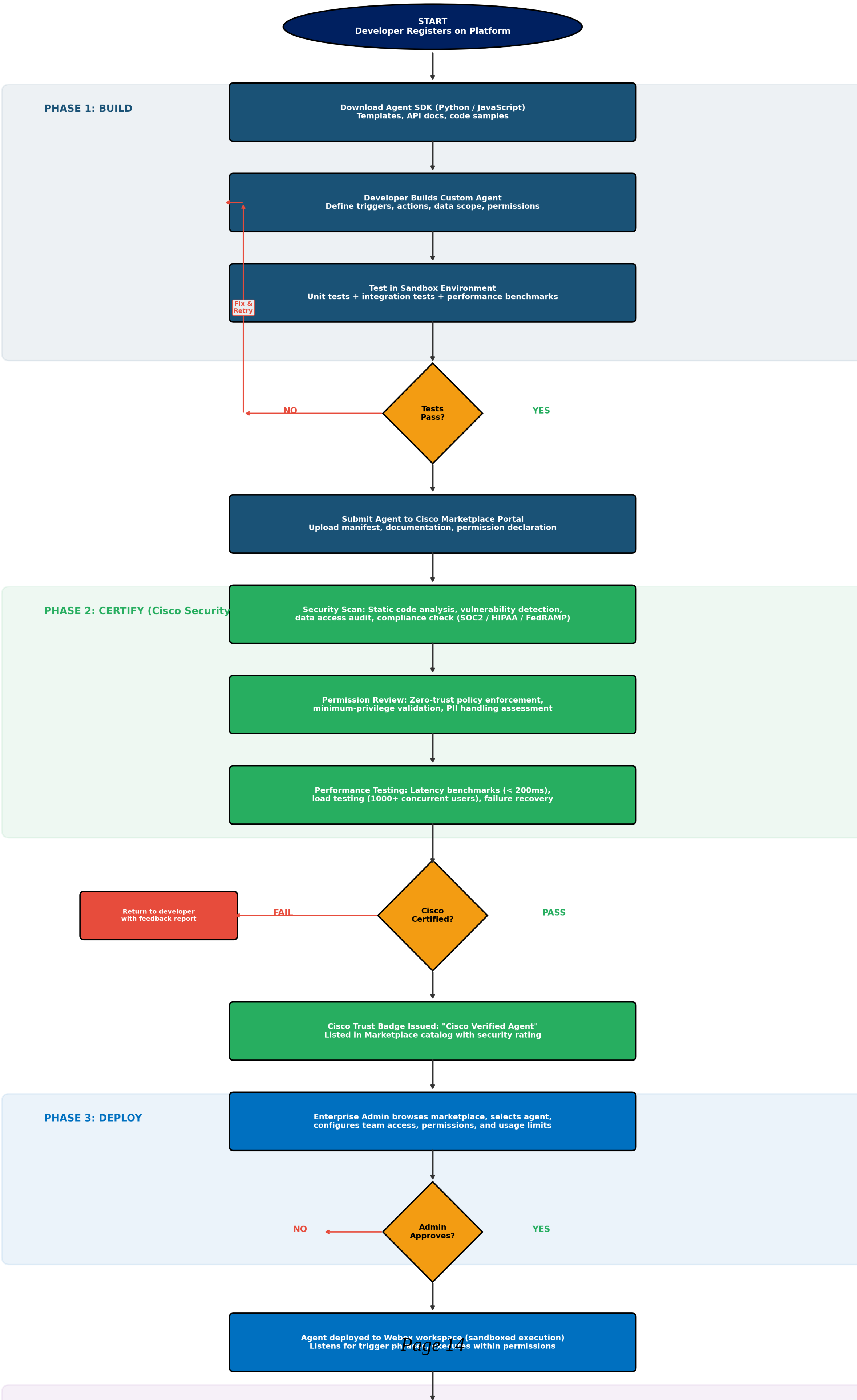
Sources: Cisco FY2024 10-K; Splunk platform documentation; Salesforce AppExchange economics model; Apple App Store developer revenue sharing framework; MarketsandMarkets Agentic AI Market Report 2024.

Solution 3 Flowchart: Secure AI Agent Marketplace

The following flowchart details the complete Build-Certify-Deploy-Monitor lifecycle, including the Cisco security certification pipeline, enterprise admin deployment controls, Splunk-powered monitoring, and example marketplace agents across five industry verticals.

Solution 3: Secure AI Agent Marketplace

Build -> Certify -> Deploy -> Monitor Lifecycle



Integrated Strategy: How the Three Solutions Work Together

The three solutions are designed as an integrated system, not independent initiatives. Together, they create a comprehensive competitive moat:

- Solution 1 (Agentic AI Orchestrator) provides the core intelligence: AI that can perceive meeting context, reason about tasks, and execute actions across enterprise systems.
- Solution 2 (Meeting-to-Action Engine) applies that intelligence to the highest-value use case: converting meetings from time sinks into productivity engines with automated follow-through.
- Solution 3 (AI Agent Marketplace) scales the intelligence: instead of Cisco building every agent, the marketplace enables thousands of developers to build vertical-specific agents for healthcare, finance, government, manufacturing, and more.

The combined impact makes Webex indispensable rather than interchangeable. Users stay on Webex not because the video quality is marginally better, but because leaving means losing their AI agents, their automated workflows, and the productivity gains that accumulate over time.

Combined Projected Impact

Metric	Projected Value
Daily Active Usage Increase	+35% within 12 months of full deployment
Meeting-to-Action Conversion	25% (vs. current ~5% industry average)
Post-Meeting Follow-Up Time	Reduced from 45 min to 5 min per meeting
Action Item Completion Rate	92% on-time (vs. 27% industry baseline)
Marketplace Certified Agents	500+ in Year 1, 2,000+ by Year 3
Developer Ecosystem Growth	3x within 18 months
Enterprise Renewal Rate	85% (driven by agent-specific stickiness)
Incremental Collaboration ARR	+$2.1 billion by FY2029
Marketplace Commission Revenue	$50M annually by FY2029
Productivity Savings per Worker	$4,200 per knowledge worker per year

Sources: IDC UC&C Market Tracker 2024; MarketsandMarkets Agentic AI Report; Cisco FY2024 10-K; Microsoft Work Trend Index 2024; McKinsey Future of Work Report 2024.

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